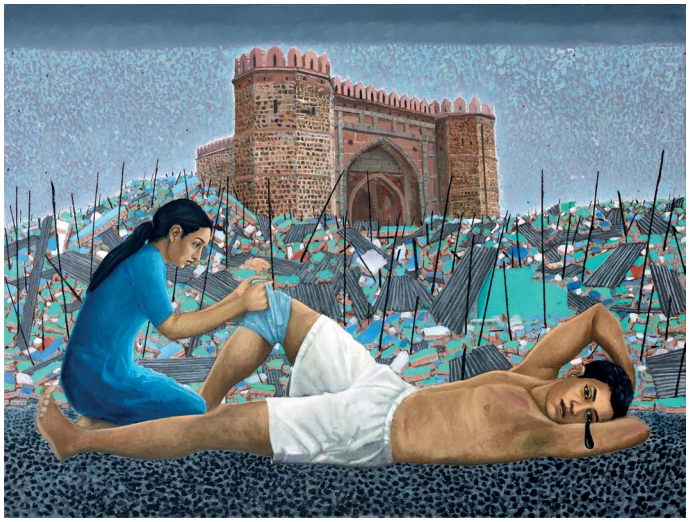
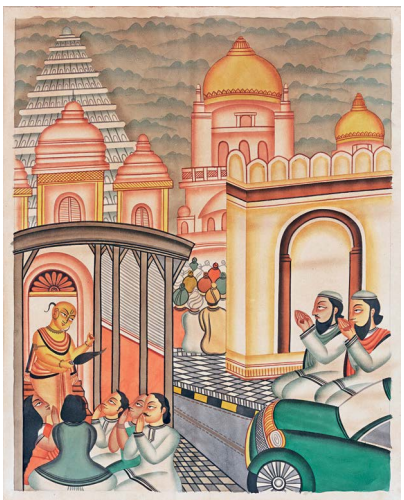


ODE TO THE PAST
Clockwise from left, A work by K.P. Reji and Guild Art, exhibits at *Joining the Dots*; works by Veda Raheja, Dhruv Vaish and Anwar Chitrakar







GALLERY

OLD STROKES, NEW DELHI

Dhoomimal Gallery's ongoing exhibition, *Joining the Dots,* is a tribute to the enduring charm of Delhi's cultural heart—Connaught Place

When India's oldest contemporary art gallery, Dhoomimal, located in the heart of Delhi, decides to pay homage to the illustrious history of the neighbourhood it belongs to—Connaught Place—it would be remiss not to revisit its own history at the same time. Established in 1936, the gallery's 88-year-long legacy is intrinsically woven into the fabric of one of Delhi's primary and oldest commercial hubs, for which art historian and curator Annapurna Garimella has a deep, abiding love she crystallised into the ongoing exhibition *Joining the Dots: The Past Has a Home in the Future* through her Bengaluru-based research and design organisation, Jackfruit.

On display till December 7, the exhibition chronicles the history of Connaught Place as a crucible for cultural and political exchanges documented and romanticised in various art forms over the decades. "Don't you absolutely love Connaught Place?" asks Garimella, who calls this show her love letter to Delhi, which she finds herself returning to again and again.

"As grad students, Connaught Place is where we all came to buy books or to grab a bite. And it is here that I started to learn about the history of Delhi—whether it was Gurcharan Singh's pottery or the Lalit Kala Akademi where people assembled to exchange ideas," says Garimella. "Just walking through Connaught Place, I learned about Rikhi Ram & Sons, which is where The Beatles bought their musical instruments, as did Pandit Ravi Shankar and Krishna Mohan Bhatt, my friend and a sitar player, who is slated to perform on one of the days at the show," she says.

THE SHOW CHRONICLES THE HISTORY OF CONNAUGHT PLACE AS DOCUMENTED AND ROMANTICISED IN VARIOUS ART FORMS

The exhibition, laid out in three parts, charts the history of Connaught Place in meticulous detail. Following Independence, a new cultural economy of India was conceived to craft an identity of the nation globally, which led to an exploration of the arts and design in search of what could be truly "Indian". The phase from 1947 to 1984 is sectioned into the elements of line, shape, movement and community to delineate visual, spatial and relational aspects of what came to represent India.

'Line' explores the drawings of artists; 'shape' looks at objects, artworks and their materiality; 'movement' underlines the motions of an infant democracy through the sounds and visuals emerging from it, while 'community' commemorates the passion and relationships forged